

IN PROFILE

Jane Stirling

Chopin had many wealthy pupils, of whom the most significant in his life was Jane Stirling (1804–1859), who came from a Scottish landowning family. They met in about 1843 and it was Stirling who promoted his stay in England and Scotland in 1848. She had romantic feelings for Chopin, but they were not returned: he came to find her attentions wearing and wrote to a friend, “I am closer to the coffin than the marriage bed.” Her devotion continued after his death, when she paid for his lavish funeral, bought most of his estate, and did much to preserve his legacy.

“Chopin ... made a **single instrument** speak a **language of infinity.** ”

GEORGE SAND

A week after he arrived in Vienna, news came that a rebellion against the Russians had broken out in Warsaw. Chopin was advised by his parents not to return home but to stay away from the bloodshed. Lonely and homesick, he made little headway in Vienna, so decided to move to Paris, arriving in September 1831. On the journey, he heard that Warsaw had been captured by the Russians, an event said to have inspired one of his most turbulent pieces, the “Revolutionary” Etude, which packs a torrent of emotion into less than three minutes of music.